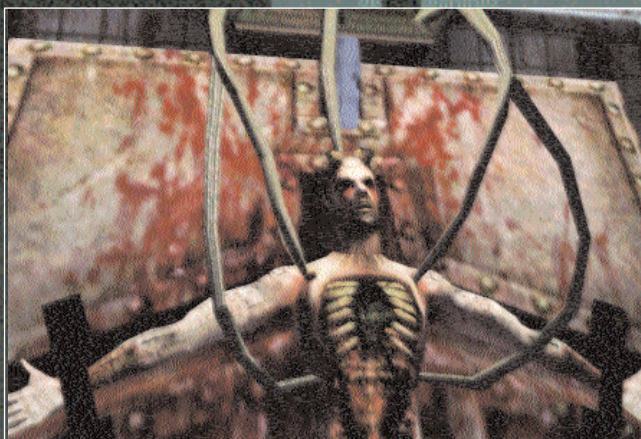




relocate your heart to the general vicinity of your throat. Something that deserves mention here is the escape sequences—scripted though they are, they're still the most heart-pounding parts of the game, where you run like hell, bolting doors and using obstacles to delay enemies by *just* those critical few seconds that stand between you and your coffin. You don't even have a gun in the first chase—a chilling “ohmygodIamgonnadie” feeling. The mix doesn't work as well as an all-out FPS, but it's still one of the better approaches we've seen.

It isn't as straightforward as it sounds, though. You have to remember that even though Jack has been released from the asylum, his mind isn't made of steel, and every disturbing scene he encounters will take a toll on his sanity—his heartbeat quickens, his breathing becomes heavier, his vision blurs—and as this worsens, he will start to mutter to himself, see things, and finally liberate himself with a shot from his pistol. To regain sanity, you must find the (very, very few) savepoints, which give him (and you) a few deserved moments of sanctuary. The idea could have been disastrous, but works in beautifully with the game's extremely immersive atmosphere.

FPS junkies will find the lack of a Heads-Up Display a little disconcerting, but you'll see that it's all part of the experience. There's no accurate gauge of health on-screen, but you can listen to your heartbeat and breathing to decide whether you need to patch up with a few bandages, or if you need a shot of morphine. Of course, this assumes your heart isn't thumping in real life. The health system is much more advanced than your average oh-now-I'm-hurt-but-everything-still-functions-properly. If you get shot in the arm, you won't be able to aim your gun well, a wound to the leg and you'll be limping, and an unattended bleeding wound will gradually drain you of life.

I can't say this enough—*DCoTE* is *creepy*. The story is brilliant (*The Shadow over Innsmouth* and *The Call of Cthulhu* can freely be read online, incidentally), the atmosphere is eerie, and the gameplay is as realistic as it can be—from the superb health system to the very life-like reasoning it takes to get out of tight spots.

And if you're feeling particularly brave, take the game's challenge and play it with the lights off. ■

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Rating: 9/10
Minimum System Requirements: PIII 800, 32 MB Direct3D compatible graphics card, 128 MB RAM
Developer: HeadFirst Productions
Publisher: Ubisoft
Distributor: E-Xpress Interactive
Contact: 022-22850245
Price: To Be Announced